

D670

# Elementary Literacy Methods

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

**What this is.** Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

**Source.** Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

Method © 2026 Erik Daniel Lindquist — Course Mastery Coach, armored drill. Items drafted with AI assistance under his direction.

## How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

| Target word | The one fact that decides | Answer | [ ] sure [ ] unsure [ ] guess |
|-------------|---------------------------|--------|-------------------------------|
| _____       | _____                     | _____  |                               |

# Items

1.

A fifth-grade teacher is choosing words to teach from a novel set in a fishing village. The words include “boat,” “reluctant,” “trawler,” and “ran.” The novel won an award, and the class reads it in October. Which word deserves the most direct instruction?

- A. reluctant
- B. ran
- C. boat
- D. trawler

| Target word | The one fact that decides | Answer | [ ] sure [ ] unsure [ ] guess |
|-------------|---------------------------|--------|-------------------------------|
| _____       | _____                     | ___    |                               |

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A science unit on cells includes the word “mitochondria.” Which tier is it, and how should it be taught?

- A. Skip it, since all science words are too hard.
- B. Tier 2; give it the most vocabulary time across all subjects.
- C. Tier 3; teach it within the science content where it is needed.
- D. Tier 1; no teaching needed.

| Target word | The one fact that decides | Answer | [ ] sure [ ] unsure [ ] guess |
|-------------|---------------------------|--------|-------------------------------|
| _____       | _____                     | ___    |                               |

3.

A sixth grader freezes at the word “unpredictable” in a social studies text. He plays on a travel baseball team and reads well in short words. Which strategy best helps him?

- A. Break it into un- + predict + -able, read each part, and use the parts to infer the meaning.
- B. Skip the word and keep reading.
- C. Guess from the first letter.
- D. Use baseball words to help.

| Target word | The one fact that decides | Answer | [ ] sure [ ] unsure [ ] guess |
|-------------|---------------------------|--------|-------------------------------|
| _____       | _____                     | ___    |                               |

**4.** [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Students know that “port” means carry. Which word would they be able to figure out using the same root plus a known prefix meaning “across”?

- A.** portrait
- B.** report
- C.** important
- D.** transport

| Target word | The one fact that decides | Answer | [ ] sure [ ] unsure [ ] guess |
|-------------|---------------------------|--------|-------------------------------|
| _____       | _____                     | ___    |                               |

**5.**

A fourth-grade teacher wants students to summarize nonfiction paragraphs. The class has a new rug and a student teacher from a nearby university. What should the first lesson include?

- A.** Students summarize five paragraphs alone.
- B.** Let the student teacher decide how to teach it.
- C.** The teacher names the strategy and thinks aloud while summarizing a paragraph, then guides students through one together.
- D.** Give a definition of summarizing and a worksheet.

| Target word | The one fact that decides | Answer | [ ] sure [ ] unsure [ ] guess |
|-------------|---------------------------|--------|-------------------------------|
| _____       | _____                     | ___    |                               |

**6.**

A passage says: “Because the river flooded, farms were ruined. As a result, food prices rose.” The passage has a photo of a bridge and is 400 words long. Which organizer best fits the text structure?

- A.** A timeline of dates
- B.** A cause-and-effect chain
- C.** A Venn diagram
- D.** A labeled photo of the bridge

| Target word | The one fact that decides | Answer | [ ] sure [ ] unsure [ ] guess |
|-------------|---------------------------|--------|-------------------------------|
| _____       | _____                     | ___    |                               |

**7.** [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A teacher wants students to practice compare-and-contrast structure. Which sentence contains the best signal words for that structure?

- A.** “Because the pond dried up, the frogs moved.”
- B.** “Frogs are green and have long legs.”
- C.** “First, the egg hatches. Next, the tadpole grows legs.”
- D.** “Frogs live near water; similarly, toads need moisture. However, toads can live in drier places.”

| Target word | The one fact that decides | Answer | [ ] sure [ ] unsure [ ] guess |
|-------------|---------------------------|--------|-------------------------------|
| _____       | _____                     | ___    |                               |

**8.**

Fifth graders who decode well struggle with an article about coral reefs. Most have never been to the ocean. The article came from a children's magazine with a shiny cover. What would most improve comprehension?

- A.** More decoding practice.
- B.** Build knowledge first with a short video, images, and an easier connected text about reefs.
- C.** Use a magazine with a plain cover.
- D.** Assign a random passage on a new topic to practice skills.

| Target word | The one fact that decides | Answer | [ ] sure [ ] unsure [ ] guess |
|-------------|---------------------------|--------|-------------------------------|
| _____       | _____                     | ___    |                               |

**9.**

A teacher is writing discussion questions for a story about a girl who saves a stray dog. The story is 6 pages long and was written by a local author. Which question is most text-dependent?

- A.** “Do you like dogs?”
- B.** “Where does the author live?”
- C.** “What details show how the girl's feelings about the dog change? Cite two.”
- D.** “Have you ever had a pet?”

| Target word | The one fact that decides | Answer | [ ] sure [ ] unsure [ ] guess |
|-------------|---------------------------|--------|-------------------------------|
| _____       | _____                     | ___    |                               |

10.

A sixth grader with dyslexia reads two grade levels below but understands grade-level science when it is read aloud. He is a strong artist and likes building models. Which plan best supports him?

- A. Let him replace all reading with art projects.
- B. Withhold audio until his reading reaches grade level.
- C. Give audio text only and stop reading instruction.
- D. Continue explicit structured decoding and spelling instruction and provide audio text for grade-level content.

| Target word | The one fact that decides | Answer | [ ] sure [ ] unsure [ ] guess |
|-------------|---------------------------|--------|-------------------------------|
| _____       | _____                     | ___    |                               |

11.

A fourth-grade teacher's fall screening shows 9 of 30 students below benchmark in comprehension. The school has a strong PTA and a new reading nook. What percentage is below benchmark, and what should happen first?

- A. 9%; no change needed.
- B. 30%; strengthen core Tier 1 instruction for the whole class.
- C. 30%; send all 9 students to Tier 3 intervention.
- D. 30%; add more books to the reading nook.

| Target word | The one fact that decides | Answer | [ ] sure [ ] unsure [ ] guess |
|-------------|---------------------------|--------|-------------------------------|
| _____       | _____                     | ___    |                               |

12. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

In a class of 25, core instruction is working well by the usual benchmark of about 80% of students meeting expectations. What is the most students who could be below benchmark?

- A. 5
- B. 8
- C. 0, since good core instruction reaches every student.
- D. 20

| Target word | The one fact that decides | Answer | [ ] sure [ ] unsure [ ] guess |
|-------------|---------------------------|--------|-------------------------------|
| _____       | _____                     | ___    |                               |

# STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

# Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

## 1. Answer A Concept 1

A fifth-grade teacher is choosing words to teach from a novel set in a fishing village. The words include “boat,” “reluctant,” “trawler,” and “ran.” ~~The novel won an award, and the class reads it in October.~~ Which word deserves the most direct instruction?

**Target word:** choose a Tier 2 word **Decides:** High-utility academic word.

|   |                   |                                                             |
|---|-------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| A | <b>Correct</b>    | Tier 2: used across many texts and subjects.                |
| B | Dropped element   | Tier 1 everyday word.                                       |
| C | Confusion set     | Tier 1, already known.                                      |
| D | Adjacent category | Tier 3, domain-specific; a quick definition is enough here. |

## 2. Answer C Concept 1 • transfer

A science unit on cells includes the word “mitochondria.” Which tier is it, and how should it be taught?

**Target word:** reverse: classify and plan **Decides:** Domain-specific word.

|   |                    |                                                      |
|---|--------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| A | Absolute language  | Content words are needed to learn the content.       |
| B | Inverted operation | It is not a cross-subject academic word.             |
| C | <b>Correct</b>     | Domain-specific words are taught with their content. |
| D | Confusion set      | Not an everyday word.                                |

## 3. Answer A Concept 2

A sixth grader freezes at the word “unpredictable” in a social studies text. ~~He plays on a travel baseball team and reads well in short words.~~ Which strategy best helps him?

**Target word:** morphology **Decides:** A long word built from known parts.

|   |                   |                                                 |
|---|-------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| A | <b>Correct</b>    | Morphology supports decoding and meaning.       |
| B | Dropped element   | Drops the word instead of building skill.       |
| C | Adjacent category | Guessing does not build decoding of long words. |
| D | Camouflage        | Interest does not decode the word.              |

## 4. Answer D Concept 2 • transfer

Students know that “port” means carry. Which word would they be able to figure out using the same root plus a known prefix meaning “across”?

**Target word:** reverse: build a word from parts **Decides:** trans- (across) + port (carry).

|   |                    |                                              |
|---|--------------------|----------------------------------------------|
| A | Confusion set      | Shares letters but not the root meaning.     |
| B | Adjacent category  | Uses the root with re- (back), not “across.” |
| C | Inverted operation | Adds a prefix that does not mean across.     |
| D | <b>Correct</b>     | trans- + port = carry across.                |

## 5. Answer C Concept 3

A fourth-grade teacher wants students to summarize nonfiction paragraphs. ~~The class has a new rug and a student teacher from a nearby university.~~ What should the first lesson include?

**Target word:** explicit strategy instruction **Decides:** Model before release.

|          |                    |                                                   |
|----------|--------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| A        | Inverted operation | Skips modeling and guided practice.               |
| B        | Camouflage         | Who teaches does not settle the method.           |
| <b>C</b> | <b>Correct</b>     | Explicit modeling and guided practice come first. |
| D        | Dropped element    | Drops the modeling.                               |

## 6. Answer B Concept 4

A passage says: “Because the river flooded, farms were ruined. As a result, food prices rose.” ~~The passage has a photo of a bridge and is 400 words long.~~ Which organizer best fits the text structure?

**Target word:** identify structure **Decides:** Signal words: because, as a result.

|          |                   |                                         |
|----------|-------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| A        | Adjacent category | Sequence, not causation.                |
| <b>B</b> | <b>Correct</b>    | Signal words show cause and effect.     |
| C        | Confusion set     | Used for compare/contrast.              |
| D        | Camouflage        | Reacts to the photo, not the structure. |

## 7. Answer D Concept 4 • transfer

A teacher wants students to practice compare-and-contrast structure. Which sentence contains the best signal words for that structure?

**Target word:** reverse: from structure to signal words **Decides:** Words like similarly and however.

|          |                   |                                          |
|----------|-------------------|------------------------------------------|
| A        | Adjacent category | Cause and effect.                        |
| B        | Dropped element   | Description only; no comparison.         |
| C        | Confusion set     | Sequence signal words.                   |
| <b>D</b> | <b>Correct</b>    | Similarly and however signal comparison. |

## 8. Answer B Concept 5

Fifth graders who decode well struggle with an article about coral reefs. Most have never been to the ocean. ~~The article came from a children's magazine with a shiny cover.~~ What would most improve comprehension?

**Target word:** build background knowledge **Decides:** Decoding is strong; topic knowledge is missing.

|          |                    |                                               |
|----------|--------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| A        | Inverted operation | Decoding is already strong.                   |
| <b>B</b> | <b>Correct</b>     | Background knowledge drives comprehension.    |
| C        | Camouflage         | Cover design is irrelevant.                   |
| D        | Adjacent category  | Disconnected passages do not build knowledge. |

### 9. Answer C Concept 6

A teacher is writing discussion questions for a story about a girl who saves a stray dog. ~~The story is 6 pages long and was written by a local author.~~ Which question is most text-dependent?

**Target word:** text-dependent question **Decides:** Requires evidence from the text.

|          |                   |                                                |
|----------|-------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| A        | Dropped element   | Drops the text entirely.                       |
| B        | Camouflage        | About the author, not the text.                |
| <b>C</b> | <b>Correct</b>    | Students must return to the text for evidence. |
| D        | Adjacent category | A personal connection that needs no reading.   |

### 10. Answer D Concept 7

A sixth grader with dyslexia reads two grade levels below but understands grade-level science when it is read aloud. ~~He is a strong artist and likes building models.~~ Which plan best supports him?

**Target word:** dyslexia in upper grades **Decides:** Needs both access and continued skill instruction.

|          |                    |                                             |
|----------|--------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| A        | Camouflage         | Uses his strength but drops literacy goals. |
| B        | Inverted operation | Blocks access to content he can understand. |
| C        | Dropped element    | Drops needed skill instruction.             |
| <b>D</b> | <b>Correct</b>     | Remediation plus access.                    |

### 11. Answer B Concept 8

A fourth-grade teacher's fall screening shows 9 of 30 students below benchmark in comprehension. ~~The school has a strong PTA and a new reading nook.~~ What percentage is below benchmark, and what should happen first?

**Target word:** use Tier 1 data **Decides:**  $9 \div 30 = 30\%$ , well above about 20%.

|          |                   |                                                           |
|----------|-------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| A        | Wrong stem number | Uses the count as a percent.                              |
| <b>B</b> | <b>Correct</b>    | A large share below benchmark points to the core program. |
| C        | Adjacent category | Skips fixing the core that many students need.            |
| D        | Camouflage        | Does not address instruction.                             |

### 12. Answer A Concept 8 · transfer

In a class of 25, core instruction is working well by the usual benchmark of about 80% of students meeting expectations. What is the most students who could be below benchmark?

**Target word:** solve for number below benchmark **Decides:**  $20\%$  of  $25 = 5$ .

|          |                    |                                                         |
|----------|--------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>A</b> | <b>Correct</b>     | $80\%$ of $25 = 20$ meeting; $25 - 20 = 5$ .            |
| B        | Wrong stem number  | Uses $80 \div 10$ instead of computing $20\%$ of $25$ . |
| C        | Absolute language  | Some students need Tier 2 even with strong core.        |
| D        | Inverted operation | That is the number meeting benchmark.                   |

## Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

|                       | <b>Right</b>                                          | <b>Wrong</b>                                                                          |
|-----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Sure</b>           | Owled.                                                | <b>Concept inversion — top priority.</b> A wrong mental model; it survives rewording. |
| <b>Unsure / guess</b> | Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer. | Not learned yet.                                                                      |

## Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

| <b>Trap</b>        | <b>What it does</b>                                          | <b>In this drill</b> | <b>Your misses</b> |
|--------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------|--------------------|
| Dropped element    | Leaves out a required term or step.                          | 6                    |                    |
| Wrong stem number  | A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.      | 2                    |                    |
| Adjacent category  | The right idea in the wrong bucket.                          | 8                    |                    |
| Inverted operation | Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower. | 6                    |                    |
| Absolute language  | Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.           | 2                    |                    |
| Confusion set      | Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.       | 5                    |                    |
| Camouflage         | Answers a stem fact that was never the question.             | 7                    |                    |

# Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

| # | Concept                                              | Rule                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | Trap                                                                                                           | Tell                                                            |
|---|------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | <b>Vocabulary tiers</b>                              | Tier 2 words are high-utility academic words used across subjects (analyze, reluctant) and deserve the most direct instruction; Tier 1 are everyday words; Tier 3 are domain-specific terms taught with their content. | Spending most vocabulary time on rare, domain-specific Tier 3 words or on words students already know.         | Choosing which words from a text to teach.                      |
| 2 | <b>Morphology for multisyllabic words</b>            | Teaching prefixes, suffixes, and roots helps upper-elementary students decode and infer the meaning of long words.                                                                                                     | Telling students to skip long words or guess from context only.                                                | A student stuck on words like “unpredictable.”                  |
| 3 | <b>Explicit comprehension strategy instruction</b>   | Name the strategy, model it with a think-aloud, guide practice, then release to independent use.                                                                                                                       | Assigning “use a strategy” without modeling how.                                                               | Introducing summarizing, questioning, or inferring.             |
| 4 | <b>Informational text structure</b>                  | Recognizing structure (cause/effect, compare/contrast, problem/solution, sequence, description) helps students organize and recall information; signal words are clues.                                                | Treating all informational text as a list of facts.                                                            | Signal words such as because, as a result, however, similarly.  |
| 5 | <b>Background knowledge drives comprehension</b>     | Students understand text better when they know about the topic; building knowledge through connected texts is part of comprehension instruction.                                                                       | Believing skills practice on random passages is enough.                                                        | Strong decoders who struggle on unfamiliar topics.              |
| 6 | <b>Text-dependent questions and close reading</b>    | Good comprehension questions require students to return to the text and cite evidence.                                                                                                                                 | Asking personal-connection questions that can be answered without reading.                                     | Writing discussion questions for a passage.                     |
| 7 | <b>Supporting upper-grade students with dyslexia</b> | Continue explicit, structured decoding and spelling instruction while giving accommodations (such as audio text) so students can access grade-level content.                                                           | Replacing reading instruction with accommodations only, or withholding accommodations until decoding is fixed. | An older student with dyslexia and grade-level content demands. |
| 8 | <b>Using Tier 1 data</b>                             | If a large share of a class (often more than about 20%) is below benchmark, strengthen core instruction for all before relying on small-group intervention.                                                            | Sending many students to intervention when the core program is the problem.                                    | The percentage of a class below benchmark.                      |

**Course scope (public description):** Elementary Literacy Methods is an engaging and comprehensive course designed for aspiring educators, focusing on the development of effective literacy teaching strategies for elementary-level students. This course reviews the fundamental principles of literacy education through science of

reading, but takes a more specialized focus on vocabulary development, reading comprehension, and the deeply complex literacy skills developed in grades 4 to 6. Candidates explore a variety of instructional approaches and materials tailored to support all learners in the elementary classroom, including learners with dyslexia. This exposure will assist candidates in using Tier 1 multi-tiered systems of support and assessment (MTSS) for planning and implementing literacy lessons, selecting appropriate resources, and assessing student progress.